

In car infotainment systems have matured quite a bit over the last few years, keeping the smartphone at the centre. The most sophisticated infotainment systems nowadays provide a wide range of connectivity and app support for smartphones, and mirror its activity through native firmware. The large variety of automakers have a large variety of infotainment interfaces to differentiate themselves amidst similar features and functionalities.

Despite the need for differentiating, it is also important to have a uniform interface for the sake of easing a user's learning curve. It is here, that Apple CarPlay finds its niche.

Where it all began

Back in 2010, when in-car entertainment and technology was largely restricted to music players equipped with Bluetooth, Apple launched the iPhone 4. Among the many improvements that came with it was a hidden feature called 'iPod Out'. Never heard of it? Well, very few did, to be honest.

iPod Out was developed by Apple in collaboration with the BMW Group's technology arm. It required a car's central system to have a display and a USB port. One would simply plug in the iPhone cable with the infotainment system, and enable iPod Out to host the phone's screen to the car's display. The features of the display could then be controlled via in-car buttons, and even steering-mounted buttons.



The first car with CarPlay was quite an extravagant one!